Seeing Clearly: Parshat Re’eh, the Third Haftarah of Consolation, and the Threshold of Elul

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25 Av 5786 — Shabbat Mevarchim Elul

The calendar places this Motzei Shabbat at a precise junction: the reading of Parshat Re’eh, the third of the Seven Haftarot of Consolation, and the Shabbat on which the coming month of Elul is blessed. The portion opens with a command that is at once singular and collective: “See, I set before you today a blessing and a curse” (Deuteronomy 11:26). The Haftarah addresses the “afflicted, storm-tossed one who has not been comforted” and invites every thirsty soul to the water that sustains without price. Together they frame the threshold of Elul as a season of deliberate vision, free choice, and the active reception of consolation through Torah and mitzvah.

The Opening Demand of Vision

The word *re’eh* stands at the head of the portion. Classical commentators note the shift from singular to plural: the individual is called to see, while the consequences confront the entire community. Rashi anchors the verse in the concrete ceremony to be enacted on Mount Gerizim and Mount Eival after entry into the Land. The people must see with their own eyes the concrete results of obedience and disobedience. The choice is not abstract; it is proclaimed publicly, witnessed communally, and bound to the inheritance of the Land itself.

The portion proceeds through the laws that give institutional form to that choice: the centralized sanctuary that forbids the multiplication of private altars, the absolute rejection of idolatry and of the false prophet who would lead the people away from the covenant, the dietary distinctions that train the body in holiness, the laws of tithing and the sabbatical release that protect the vulnerable and prevent the permanent concentration of land and power, the three pilgrimage festivals that gather the nation before the Presence, and the demand that justice and compassion govern the gates of the community. These are not peripheral regulations. They constitute the architecture of a people that has accepted the responsibility of seeing clearly and choosing deliberately.

The Third Consolation: From Affliction to Living Water

The Haftarah (Isaiah 54:11–55:5) belongs to the sequence of consolation that follows the three weeks of mourning. The prophet addresses Zion as the one still uncomforted after storm and affliction. He promises foundations of sapphire, walls of precious stones, children taught of the Lord and established in abundant peace, and the nullification of every weapon formed against her. The second movement turns from physical restoration to spiritual invitation: “Ho, all who thirst, come to the water\ldots buy wine and milk without money and without price.” Torah is compared to water that quenches, wine that gladdens, and milk that nurtures. The everlasting covenant promised to David is extended to the people, culminating in the nations running to Israel because of the Holy One of Israel.

In the reading of the classical meforshim, Radak situates the prophecy after destruction and reads the precious stones as both literal rebuilding and the spiritual radiance that will accompany return. Metzudat David and Metzudat Tzion trace the narrative arc from affliction to invincible peace and then to the free invitation of Torah. Malbim emphasizes the moral psychology: the thirsty soul must actively come; the covenant with David models a kingship that elevates an entire people. Abarbanel frames the prophecy philosophically as the ultimate resolution of exile through the re-establishment of a just, G-d-centered polity. Midrashim link the "water" of Torah to the well that accompanied Israel in the wilderness and to the living waters of the future.

Chassidic interpretation, especially in Torah Or and Likkutei Torah on related themes, internalizes the choice. Every Jew must "see" the G-dliness latent in the material. The consolation of Isaiah becomes the revelation of the essence of the soul that was never truly in exile. The physical luxury of precious stones points to the revelation of the inner light of the soul and of the Land itself in the era of Geulah. The call to "come to the water" is the practical *avodah* of intensified Torah study that alone quenches the thirst of the *neshamah* and prepares the vessel for final consolation. Consolation is not passive; it is received by those who turn toward the Source. The same demand for clear-eyed choice that opens the Parsha reappears as the demand to distinguish true nourishment from empty substitutes.

The Lubavitcher Rebbe's Emphasis

Across Likkutei Sichos, Sefer HaSichos, and related maamarim, the Rebbe returns repeatedly to the third of the Seven of Consolation as the moment when the people's cry for direct Divine comfort is answered. The afflicted one is not merely comforted by prophetic words; she is told that the Comforter Himself will console her. The precious stones are the revelation of the hidden lights of the soul and of the Land. The invitation "all who thirst, come to the water" is the practical work of the week: intensify Torah study so that the thirst of the generation is met. The everlasting covenant with David points toward the ultimate kingship of Moshiach, yet the preparation remains the everyday choice of blessing over curse, of Torah over empty substitutes. Personal *avodah* becomes public responsibility: education of children, moral courage in the face of surrounding culture, and the unity that turns a storm-tossed people into a vessel for Geulah.

Tanya: Sowing Righteousness and the Sprouting of Salvation

The daily Tanya portion opens Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 8. The verse "He sows *tzedakot* and causes *yeshu'ot* to sprout" is expounded through the image of sowing. Every act of charity and righteousness performed by Israel ascends as an elevation of *mayin nukvin* to the root of the souls above—the *Shechinah*, *Knesset Yisrael*. Through that elevation the actual *chesed* of the Lord is aroused, a revelation of His light that descends and radiates in great manifestation, at least during the time of prayer. Man's kindness converts the darkness of the body into light; this conversion is called salvation. The disproportionate revelation that follows human initiative teaches that the small act of turning toward the other and toward the Divine draws down a response that far exceeds the measure of the deed.

This teaching converges with the Haftarah's free invitation. The water, wine, and milk are available without price, yet one must come. The sowing of *tzedakah*—whether material or the righteousness of choosing Torah over substitutes—prepares the ground for the sprouting of consolation and salvation. The same dynamic governs the approach to Elul: the daily decision to drink deeply of Torah is itself a form of sowing that invites the disproportionate response of Divine nearness.

Hayom Yom: The Education of Daughters to Torah

The Hayom Yom for 25 Menachem Av records the teaching of the Rebbe Rashab, received in the name of the earlier Rebbeim: even when a daughter is born one is to say the words "to Torah" (May her parents bring her up to Torah, to marriage, and to good deeds). This rests on the statement of the Sages (Berachot 17a) concerning how women earn merit: by ensuring that their children study Torah, that their husbands go to the Study Hall, and by awaiting their return.

The teaching underscores that the transmission of Torah is a shared communal responsibility that includes the education of daughters. In the light of the Haftarah's promise that "all your children shall be taught of the Lord," the Hayom Yom insists that the next generation—sons and daughters alike—must be formed in the living waters of Torah. Chinuch is not peripheral to consolation; it is one of the principal means by which a storm-tossed people becomes a vessel capable of receiving and transmitting the Divine presence.

Sanctification of the New Month and the Daily Tehillim

The daily Rambam cycle includes the laws of the Sanctification of the New Month (chapter 9), fitting for Shabbat Mevarchim. The declaration of the new moon is a communal act of recognition and acceptance of the calendar that structures sacred time. It is itself a form of "seeing" and choosing: the community publicly affirms the order that will govern its days. The daily Tehillim portion for the 25th of Av is Psalm 119:1–96, the great acrostic of longing for the paths of Torah, the pure who walk in the law of the Lord, and the soul that clings to the commandments as to life itself. The psalm supplies the inner language of the thirst that the Haftarah invites to the water.

Synthesis: Covenantal Choice and Republican Order

The opening word of the Parsha and the invitation of the Haftarah converge on a single demand: see clearly, choose deliberately, and come thirsty to the living water. A free people inherits its land and its future only when it builds institutions of justice, protects the vulnerable through the laws of tithing and release, and refuses the false prophets of the age. Consolation is not a private feeling; it is a public rebuilding grounded in covenant.

The republican parallel is structural rather than metaphorical. A polity that will not see the difference between blessing and curse, between living water and counterfeit drink, cannot sustain free institutions. The Torah's demand for justice in the gates, for the protection of the stranger, the orphan, and the widow, and for the centralized yet non-idolatrous worship of the true G-d supplies the moral architecture that any enduring republic requires. Freedom is not license; it is ordered liberty under a higher law that the people themselves must choose, daily and communally. The festivals function as formative civic rituals that transmit collective

memory and gratitude. The education of children in the knowledge of the Lord is the transmission of the covenant across generations. The rejection of idolatry is the refusal of every form of domination—whether by false gods, by concentrated power, or by the empty substitutes that claim to quench the thirst of the soul.

The synthesis is not without tension. Secular republican theory can articulate non-domination and civic virtue, yet without the transcendent Source and the clear-eyed distinction between true and false nourishment, those forms risk becoming hollow or coercive. The Torah grounds the choice in Divine command and promise; the republican insight clarifies why that choice must be institutionalized in public justice, protected education, and the refusal of permanent hierarchies of power. The two perspectives reinforce one another when each remains faithful to its own depth.

The Realistic Path of Hope

In a generation still living in the shadow of destruction and dispersion, the Haftarah's vision of a rebuilt Jerusalem and a people whose children are taught of the Lord remains the realistic path of hope. The practical work is the same as it was then: clear choice, intensive Torah study, and the courage to reject the empty alternatives of the age. Inner growth is measured by the honesty with which one examines the idols that still compete for attention and by the daily decision to drink deeply of Torah rather than the cheaper substitutes. Public responsibility is measured by the building of institutions that protect the vulnerable, transmit the covenant to the next generation, and refuse the false prophets who offer consolation without return.

The threshold of Elul is already present. The blessing and the curse are still set before the people. The same G-d who promises to lay foundations of sapphire is the One who waits for the next step of Torah and mitzvah. Consolation is offered freely, yet it is received only by those who come.

Conclusion

Re'eh—see. The command remains urgent. See the difference between the path that leads to blessing and the path that leads to curse. See the difference between living water and the substitutes that leave the soul thirsty. Come to the water. Sow righteousness so that salvation may sprout. Educate the next generation to Torah. Bless the month that opens the season of return. The Comforter Himself awaits those who turn toward Him with clear eyes and thirsty souls.

May the blessing of Elul begin already, and may the full consolation be seen with open eyes.

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